



RPI Outdoor Programs and Rensselaer Outing Club

Backpacking Policies

Introduction:

Backpacking has the potential to be a dangerous activity. Due to this inherent danger, the conduct of this activity's leaders and participants must fall under the accepted scope of practice for Backpacking at RPI.

This document intends to standardize all Backpacking trips and will outline the guidelines and standards for which leaders are permitted to operate. These guidelines and standards meet or exceed industry standards and best practices commonly accepted by professional practitioners throughout the greater outdoor education and recreation industry.

Backpacking trip leaders are approved using the standards outlined in the document, including guidelines of conduct and the organization's accepted scope of practice. Components of this document incorporate leading industry practices, years of combined experience, and the organization's culture/legacy in high consideration.

This document is organized by Program Overview and Guiding Principles, Trip Leader Qualifications, Trips Classifications, Approved Gear List, and Proper Trip Planning and Documentation.

Program Overview and Guiding Principles:

The activity of backpacking has the potential to be interpreted differently by those who wish to define it. Typically, it describes the act of hiking while carrying personal/necessary items within a backpack. Components of elevation, duration, distance, and hiking pace can change drastically between backpacking programs. It is for these inconsistent factors that standards be set for backpacking trips that are run through Rensselaer Outdoor Programs and Outing Club. The following considerations should be present in all backpacking trips provided by RPI Outdoor Programs and its partners.

Role of the Leaders:

- When facilitating a backpacking trip, leadership needs to be established to monitor unwarranted risks to the participants, leaders, equipment, and institution.
 - Leadership is defined as:
 - Assistant Backpacking Leader (i.e., Assistant Leader)
 - Backpacking Trip Leader (i.e., Trip Leader)
- Leaders of these trips need to undergo the proper leadership development and training and possess ample knowledge for the experience they are providing.
- Trip leadership must adhere to the policies and standards that provide the framework for the experience; this includes working within the accepted scope of practice.
- Trip Leaders will act professionally while considering the needs of the participant.

Risk Management:

- Trip Leaders will prioritize risk management before, during, and following a trip.
- Numerous factors contribute to the overall safety of all who are involved in the experience.
 - Location, weather, wildlife, terrain, equipment, physical ability, health concerns, distractions, etc., all contribute to potential risks in a program.
- At no point can Trip Leaders ensure all risk factors are eliminated. However, a leader must communicate the inherent risks involved with the activity to inform participants of potential risks.
- It is a key responsibility of the Backpacking Leader to anticipate realistic risk factors and prevent exposure to the best of their ability.

Etiquette:

- Backpacking occurs in wild and remote locations that are susceptible to the negative effects of misbehaved visitors. This requires proper etiquette for all who engage in Backpacking trips through Outdoor Programs.
- Leave No Trace Principles should be followed on every trip.
- Wilderness First Aid should be administered within the scope of the trip leader's abilities.
- Personal goals or trip itineraries should be replaced if another party requiring medical assistance is needed.
- All leaders and participants will abide by Challenge by Choice and Full Value Contract practices.

General Program Policies:

- Trip leaders must abide by the Guiding Principles mentioned above.
- Trips are required to have at least one Trip Leader and one Assistant Leader.
- All trips will follow local and state laws and regulations regarding the intended activity.
- All backpacking trips will follow the Trip Plan and GRO Submission Policy.
- The maximum participant-to-leader ratio is 10:2 on a backpacking trip. A lower ratio may be required in some areas.
- Trips will not depart from the campus (or trailhead in the case of previous arrival) in the event of serious inclement weather (e.g., extreme low temperature, high wind chill/speeds, travel restrictions, avalanche warnings, ice fall, etc.)
- Independent travel is prohibited on Backpacking Trips.
- Leaders must register at all trail registries they encounter.

General Program Policies (Winter Backpacking):

- All Winter backpacking trips must travel on established trails.
- Snowshoes, hiking poles, and microspikes are the only equipment that can be used as traction aids for any Winter backpacking trips.
 - Any trips requiring additional technical gear would fall under the category of Winter Mountaineering.
- Winter Backpacking trips cannot travel through areas that have the potential for avalanches or other terrain hazards. (i.e. Slides, gullies, glaciers, below-hanging ice, scree fields/icefall, etc.)

Trip Leader Qualifications:

Aspiring Trip leaders must meet the following requirements to lead backpacking trips as either an Assistant Leader or Trip Leader.

Assistant Leader:

- Possesses current WFA and CPR/AED certifications.
- Has completed the Outdoor and Wilderness Leadership course (OWL)
- Has participated in at least one Backpacking trip through Outdoor Programs or ROC
- Can communicate effectively under stress or during exposure to harsh environments.

Trip Leader:

Backpacking Trip Leaders will have all the qualifications of an Assistant Leader as well as...

- Has participated in at least three backpacking Trips and has been an Assistant Leader on one of those trips.
- Has participated in at least one overnight backpacking trip through Outdoor Programs or ROC
- Demonstrates knowledge of proper trip preparation and planning, on-trail group management, Leave No Trace Principles, and use of backpacking equipment.
- Approval by the current ECOMM and Outdoor Programs Professional Staff

Trip Classifications:

Introductory:

Introductory trips are planned to introduce students to the skills that are required on a backpacking trip. Introductory trips should be centered around introducing, instructing, and practicing these basic outdoor living and travel skills, focusing on education and not application. Dynamics such as ease of travel, proximity to resources, and access to rescue/aid should be factors when planning Introductory-level trips. Risks associated with terrain, dangerous temperatures/wind, heights, low visibility, thin ice, and other unforeseen risks should be intentionally avoided. Miles and elevation should be supportive of those with limited experience in backcountry travel.

(Suggestions: ≤ 5 miles, $\leq 1000'$ of elevation gain, little to no exposure)

Intermediate:

Trips at the Intermediate level require participants to possess previous experience and instruction in backpacking to fully participate. Participants are required to arrive with ample experience and proper clothing/equipment for the proposed trip. Intermediate-level trips will contain some elements of risk and commitment. These elements may be exposure to weather, physical demands, technically challenging terrain, trail conditions, unique/challenging timeframes, etc. Distance and elevation are more difficult than an Introductory level trip. Some Intermediate-level trips *may* require trip leaders to carry a Garmin InReach device during the trip.

(Suggestions: ≤ 12 miles, $< 3500'$ of elevation gain, exposure is easily managed)

Advanced:

An Advanced backpacking trip is reserved for the most technically and physically demanding trips allowed by Outdoor Programs' policies. Advanced backpacking trips may require multiple days of continuous travel, exposure

to harsher weather conditions, demanding elevation gains/loss, and long traveling distances. A participant must have previous backpacking experience on Introductory and Intermediate backpacking trips and pre-approval from trip leaders before participation in an Advanced trip. Advanced Trips require trip leaders to carry a Garmin InReach device during the trip.

(Suggestions: extensive travel distance, exposure to risk, long/multiple days, remote locations, etc.)

Approved Gear Lists:

For Participants:

- Backpack
- Whistle
- Extra Clothing (shirt, socks, underwear, etc.)
- Extra Layers (Puffy, Belay Jacket, Fleece/Mid-layer, etc.)
- Trekking Poles (optional)
- Wind/Waterproof Shell and Pants
- Personal Items (Medications, sunscreen, extra contacts, hand-warmers, etc.)
- Extra Food/Fuel (high calories, no need for preparation, won't spill or spoil)

(Winter Backpacking Additions)

- Winter Hat
- Gloves or Mittens
- Snowshoes/Micro Spikes (or both)
- Trekking Poles (optional)
- Sunglasses or Ski Goggles
- Emergency Shelter (optional – emergency bivy or mylar/space blanket)
- Insulative pad (optional – sleeping pad or sitting pad)

For Leaders: (Single Day)

- Backpack
- Medical Kit
- InReach Device (Advanced Trips Requires)
- Whistle
- Map and Compass
- Trekking Poles (optional)
- Copy of Trip Sheet
- Extra Food/Water
- Extra Clothing (shirt, socks, underwear, etc.)
- Extra Layers (Puffy, Belay Jacket, Fleece/Mid layer, etc)
- Water/Windproof Shell and Pants
- Headlamp (w/ extra batteries)
- Personal Items (Medications, sunscreen, extra contacts, hand-warmers, etc.)
- Extra Food/Fuel (high calories, no need for

preparation, won't spill or spoil)

(Winter Backpacking Additions)

- Winter Hat
- Gloves or Mittens
- Snowshoes/Micro Spikes (or both)
- Sunglasses or Ski Goggles
- Backpacking Stove & Extra Fuel
- Matches/Windproof Lighter
- Repair Kits (tents/stoves/snowshoes, etc.)
- Emergency Shelter (emergency bivy or mylar/space blanket)
- Insulative pad (sleeping pad or sitting pad)

For Overnight Trips: (*In addition to everything named above)

- Additional Warm and Waterproof Clothing
- Group Tarp or Shelter
- Extra Spare Batteries
- Extra Light Sources
- Spare Matches or Lighter
- Extra Food & Fuel for Emergencies

Proper Trip Planning and Documentation:

Pre-Trip Preparations:

Before leaving campus, all trips must submit proper trip documentation under the guidelines and protocols below. It is important to have these documents in place for the protection of the participants, leaders, and the organization. Doing so ensures compliance with programmatic policies and procedures.

Outdoor Trip Plan:

A completed Outdoor Trip Plan (OTP) must be submitted to the shared Outdoor Programs' Trip Plan folder a week before the expected departure date. Notification of trip plan submission must be communicated to the Assistant Director of Outdoor Programs. In the event of trip/itinerary changes (cancellations, additions, etc.) an updated OTP must be on file before the trip departs. By not doing so, the leaders of the trip will be asked to meet with Outdoor Programs staff, members of ECOMM, and the chair of said activity for review and course of action moving forward.

Permits:

It is unlawful for individuals to access certain lands, parks, preserves, or mountains without the possession of a granted permit. Federal, state, or local agencies may require permits to access or recreate on land under their jurisdiction. There is a chance that permission is required from multiple levels of these agencies which could complicate the permitting process. It is the responsibility of the individuals who facilitate backpacking programs to ensure they are permitted to use the land in the intended way.

Waivers:

Every individual involved in an OP or ROC program needs to have an RPI Outdoor Programs Assumption of Risk/Informed Consent Release on file before the start of the program. These waivers allow the participants to make an informed decision about whether they want to participate in the program. Waivers highlight the foreseeable risks related to the activity and outline anticipated conduct and expectations of participants.

Fees:

If fees are to be collected for any purpose, students need to fill out a Charge/Payment/Adjustment sheet and submit it to OP.